and Statsenko did all he could to get them ready before the November 1 deadline.[7]

The Soviet officers and soldiers who were rushing to make the missiles operational found themselves on difficult terrain and in unusual climatic conditions for which they were ill-prepared. Colonel Dmitrii Yazov, a future Soviet minister of defense, recalled that "[t]here were no awnings in the area where the regiment was stationed. Everything was stored in the open air. There were only tents for the personnel. Given the tropical heat and high humidity, conditions were ideal for the spread of bacteria in those tents. In just a few days cans of food began to swell and explode like bombs." And Yazov's men soon discovered another problem: the trees in the grove where they sought shelter from the burning sun turned out to be poisonous. "It was not a pleasant sight," wrote Yazov, recalling his visit to the makeshift regimental hospital. "Swellings, blisters under the eyes, and festering wounds. The patients tried to drive away clouds of mosquitoes hanging over the bunks. The air was heavy with the poisonous odor of guavas; a huge, ominous black cloud was creeping up on the camp." General Pliev, who visited Yazov's regiment, ordered its relocation to a safer place.[8]

Aleksandr Voropaev, a young sergeant at the time, remembered that in his infantry regiment, stationed in the town of Torrens near Havana, spoiled food almost led to a mutiny. Because of high temperatures and even higher humidity, food went bad very quickly. "Worms began to show up in pasta and porridge, more and more of them as time went on," he recalled. The worms in the food reminded many soldiers of the mutiny on the battleship *Potemkin*, the subject of a classic Soviet film directed by Sergei Eisenstein. There the revolt began with the discovery of worms in pieces of meat in the borscht served to the sailors. The situation was serious enough for the commander of the regiment, Lieutenant Colonel Karpov, to summon his subordinates for a talk.

"What, do you think that the officers are eating different food?" wrote Voropaev, recalling his commander's words. "It's a different mess, but the food is the same. And the worms on the plates are the same. Yesterday they brought Lieutenant Colonel Krivoy and me … canned meat with pasta for lunch. And there were worms in his pasta and mine. We looked at each